

CALLING FOR ATTENTION



From desirable gadgets to status icons of adolescents, and functional communication devices to conversation pieces—different people have different reasons for buying cell phones. We test the best of them to help you satisfy your needs

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We've been testing cell phones for quite some time now. In fact for us Test Centre blokes cell phones remain one of the tests that involve the most work, and the most fun. Although the fun aspect has always prevailed, the work aspect is something that has seen increments over the past three years or so. The reason—convergence—cell phones have evolved from bricks with number pads to smaller bricks with number pads, to devices with number pads, multimedia capabilities and cameras to the tiny all-in-one computers they've become today. So we have more to test, more aspects to look at and more parameters to grade. No complaints here—double the features—we'll have double the fun!

Just when we thought more features couldn't be crammed on to a device, we see the devices themselves become sexier, something you'd want to own not for the go, but the show. All brands have become more conscious of consumers needs. Today, a user doesn't just want a cell phone with 8 GB of internal memory, PMP capabilities, 5 megapixel camera, and GPS that looks like a miniature brick. He wants style he demands a work of art—a Ferrari on a Ford's budget. Sounds impossible? Well it isn't, thanks to a little help from our oriental neighbours, who can manufacture at half the costs that we, in India, can. With most brands having moved their manufacturing units to China over the past two years cell phones have become radically cheaper. The falling costs means that vendors can finally push better products through the pipe, as consumers expand their usage patterns. So the features that you paid Rs 20,000 for two years back will be obsolete now, or at best you can get more value for money off a phone that will cost you no more than Rs 10,000 today. That, friends, is more power to the people, and India's booming cellular market with a sale of more than 85 million handsets

last year is a strong contributor the 1+ billion phones sold globally in 2007. At just 18 million odd handsets sold in 2003, we've seen a tremendous growth rate of over 400 percent over the past four years, a trend which we fully expect to continue.

Walkie-talkies And Little Else?

Rs 3,500 to Rs 8,000

Basic cell phones may be far from flagships but they rule the volumes game. Falling prices have affected cheap cell phones too, so better technologies have trickled into this price point as well, and these phones are offer a lot to someone making his first foray into the world of cell phones, or anybody looking for something basic. A far cry from the high end multimedia smartphones these little jewels fight fiercely for a market that is at best ruthless, where any lacunae in their performance is fully exploited by other market players.

Features

LGs KE770 Shine is easily the most attractive cell phone amongst these minnows. It's very well built with a full metal body, something which belies the price. The



LG K195 - Value Winner

screen is also a mirror finished affair, although at a resolution of 176 x 220 pixels the finish is the only impressive aspect of the display. The keypad is well laid out, although feedback is entirely another matter. Sony Ericsson's K550i and K530i are obviously siblings although the higher model (K550i) has a semi metal body while the other is purely plastic. The K530i does have a larger, more comfortable keypad though. The Intex Aura i2224 is a decent looking phone, but the

How We Tested

We scoured the market for phones costing no less than Rs 4,000, as this is meant to be a more comprehensive look at the cell phone market than our earlier shoot-out in January this year. For the purposes of comparison we divided the candidates into two main categories:

1. Multimedia Phones
2. PDA Phones

Multimedia Phones were divided into four sub categories:

1. Phones from Rs 3,500 up to Rs 8,000
2. Phones between Rs 8,001 and Rs 15,000
3. Phones between Rs 15,001 to Rs 20,000
4. Phones above Rs 20,000

PDA phones were divided into 2 categories:

1. PDA phones up to Rs 20,000

2. PDA phones above Rs 20,000

Besides rating the phones specifications and features we also paid close attention to the ergonomics factor. We gave scores for keypad layout, keypad comfort, joystick/ joypad feedback and ease of usage, menu system and intuitiveness and placement of options, shortcut buttons on the phone and headset and multimedia buttons present on the device. Besides this we also rated the build quality of the device, keypads, and any movable parts, (such as sliders, battery covers etc) and quality of accessories.

Besides the performance of the cell phones as phones, as PMPs and as cameras we also rated their processing speeds. PDAs had a few additional points we looked at such as their performance as PDAs and the utility of the preinstalled and bundled applications.